

THE INTERNATIONAL COMMITTEE OF THE RED CROSS

IN ACTION

December 2024 / Issue 12

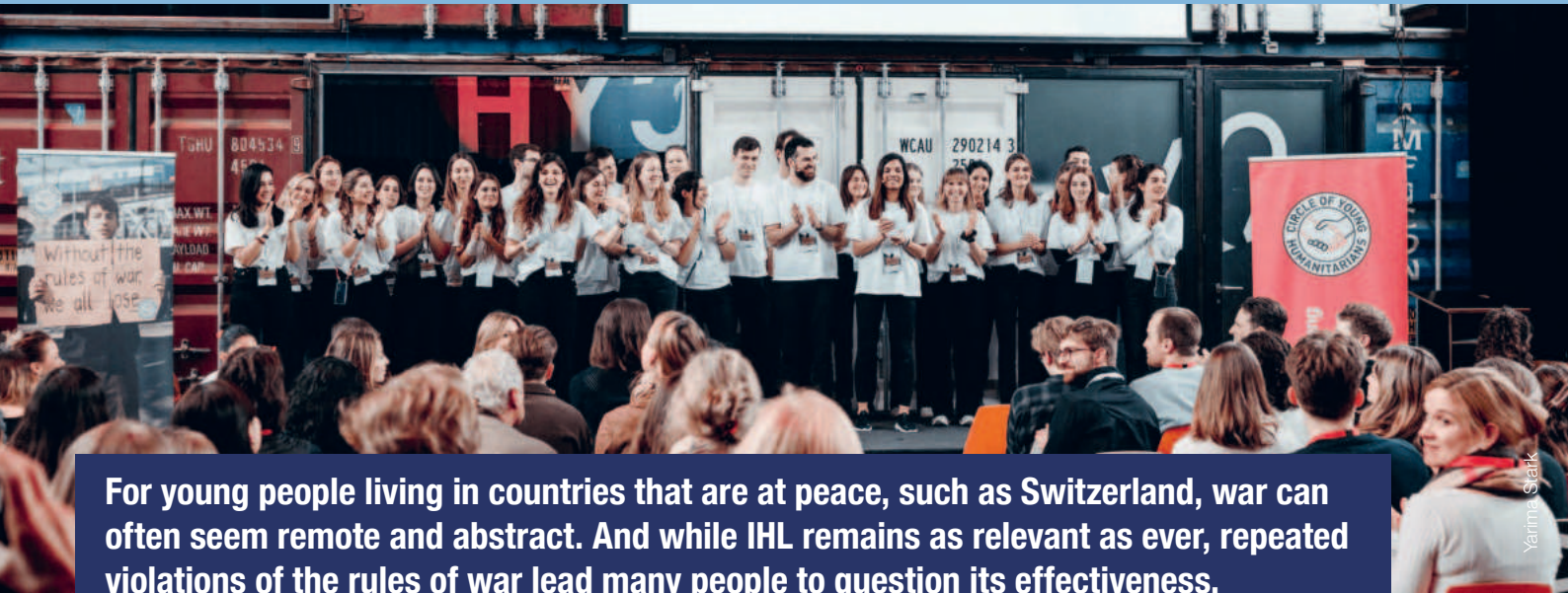


ICRC

The difference we make together

THE CIRCLE OF YOUNG HUMANITARIANS

INFLUENCING FUTURE DECISION-MAKERS FOR A FAIRER WORLD



For young people living in countries that are at peace, such as Switzerland, war can often seem remote and abstract. And while IHL remains as relevant as ever, repeated violations of the rules of war lead many people to question its effectiveness.

In 2020, the ICRC published a study entitled *Millennials on War*, which revealed some troubling opinions among young people: 41 per cent of those questioned thought that torture was acceptable under certain circumstances, while 36 per cent had doubts about the effectiveness of the Geneva Conventions in reducing suffering. It is all too easy to forget that the Geneva Conventions are quietly working behind the scenes, out of the media spotlight, continuing to save lives, as they always have since they were adopted in 1949.

The study's findings highlight the need for young people to be aware of this body of law and to understand its importance. In this digitally focused age, young people are regularly exposed to images of conflict and war on social media, and many of them feel a deep sense of powerlessness. And among the great volume of information available is misinformation, which can lead to polarization.

When I co-founded the Circle of Young Humanitarians in the spring of 2021, in coordination with the ICRC, I wanted to bridge the gap that can exist between the humanitarian world and the next generation. Why? Because we know that the way young people view war and other humanitarian emergencies today will influence the direction of the world tomorrow.

The Circle of Young Humanitarians is a non-profit, politically neutral organization based in Zurich. Over the past three years, we have mobilized more than 100 volunteers and reached over three million people through events and our media presence.

In March 2024, we held our flagship event – the Young Humanitarian Summit. This two-day forum brought together more than 300 young people and allowed for intergenerational and interdisciplinary discussions on a range of humanitarian issues. Meetings like this help young people to understand the meaning and relevance of humanitarian principles – such as neutrality – and how they apply in the real world.

We are in the process of setting up a hub in Geneva that will allow us to strengthen our impact in stable countries where there is greater access to resources and networks of influence. In this way, we hope to increase understanding of the importance of IHL among those who are not directly involved in conflicts but who play a key role in shaping humanitarian policies and initiatives at a global level.

The 2025 Young Humanitarian Summit aims to increase understanding and acceptance of IHL among young people living in countries at peace. Join us in raising awareness of the rules of war and in working towards a more humane future!

*Kay von Mérey,
President of the Circle of Young Humanitarians*



**To find out more, please contact us at:
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